> alight all the orchards, set fire to their towns, villages and hamlets, and sent up in flames many of their castles. They took their men, women and children captive, and seized a great booty of horses, mares, camels, mules, asses, oxen, cows and every kind of beast, gold and silver, all the valuables which were in their homes. . . . All the kingdom . . . was destroyed.[4]

The devastating victories placed Spain even more firmly in Christian hands.



6.1 The Spanish Peninsula, 1144

AROUND THAT SAME YEAR, the Italian scholar Gerard of Cremona traveled to the Spanish peninsula, hoping to find in the libraries of Toledo a copy of the second-century Greek astronomy text known as the *Almagest*.

He was not the first Western thinker to make the journey. A century and half earlier, the future Pope Sylvester II had traveled to a monastery near the Muslim-Christian border; there, he learned to use the numbering system of the Arabs, discovered by them in their forays into India. Unlike the cumbersome Roman system, these numbers (generally now known as Hindu-Arabic numerals) relied on place for their value. ("The Indians have a most subtle talent," marveled the monk Vigila, later in the tenth century, "this is clear in the 9 figures with which they are able to designate each and every degree of each order.") He had been followed by a whole parade of Europeans